4.5 Pollution

Pollution occurs when the environment gets contaminated by wastes, chemicals and harmful substances.

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Pollution is the damage caused to the environment mainly because of human activities. Any substance that causes pollution is known as a **pollutant**. Pollution is an unwanted change in the physical, chemical and biological characteristics of our land, air and water.

4.6 Types of Pollution

There are four major kinds of pollution:

1. Air pollution
2. Water pollution
3. Land (soil) pollution
4. Noise pollution

4.6.1 Air pollution



Most air pollution is caused by the burning of fossil fuels (e.g. oil, petrol, coal and natural gas). The are used in industries, power plants and motor vehicles. Burning these fossil fuels release toxic gases and fine particles (such as ash and soot) into the air causing air pollution. Air pollution is also caused by burning solid wastes, like some plastics, gases or chemicals released from factories and fumes from aerosols (like deodorant spray cans) or paints.

Certain toxic gases produced by industries mix with raindrops in the atmosphere and make rain unusually acidic. This is called acid rain. It damages plants, washes the nutrients out of soils and kills fish. Air pollution is harmful to all living organisms including humans. Polluted air affects skin, eyes and respiratory system.

How can we reduce air pollution?

1. Cycle or walk short distances instead of using a motor vehicle.
2. Travel by public transport (bus or train)
3. Do not burn solid waste.
4. Avoid fireworks.

4.6.2 Water pollution



Water pollution occurs when wastes from factories, houses and farms mixes with the water in rivers, lakes, ponds, the ocean or even groundwater. Contaminated or polluted water can spread diseases and chemicals which are not good for our health.

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